

as eBay even allow you to watch certain items to give you real time alerts to price fluctuations, so you can pounce on a deal as soon as it happens. Another upside to keeping a watch on a particular product through a wish/watch list is that you are well apprised of its normal cost. That way, when unscrupulous e-tailers advertise some bazillion-odd percent discount on a product you've been watching, you are well aware and cognisant of their deceptive tactics.

HUNT SMARTER WITH AGGREGATORS

While it's smart to keep a tab on product prices on different e-commerce websites through wish lists, there's a limit as to how many items you can manually track that way. Using e-commerce aggregators and price comparison websites is a much more efficient way of achieving the same. Websites such as Junglee, MySmartPrice, PriceBaba, 9lmobiles allow you to quickly look up the best prices for a particular product instantly and zero in on the e-commerce portal selling it. Also worth checking out are browser extensions such as *buyhatke*. It's not just down to price, most of these tools also allow you to find discounts and offers that make your purchase that much cheaper and value added affairs.

Comparison websites such as MySmartPrice have tie-ins with other portals, which allow them to offer reward points that can be redeemed for vouchers and gifts. These websites also make it easier for singling out products according to the discounts/prices offered across e-commerce portals. It's handy for, say, someone who isn't sure about which particular smartphone to buy, but is open to go for one in a certain price range if it's a good deal. The division of products according to various categories comes in handy to dig up excellent deals.

IT'S PAYBACK TIME

Gone are the days of brick-and-mortar stores, when socialist economic policies existed and consumer products were crappy, unreliable, required lining up in long queues, and were sold at the MRP. Then capitalism happened and that made the consumer king and spoilt for choice. In the digital age, the options are endless and even go to the point of giving con-

sumers money back for their purchases. The credit card companies are desperate for you to use their services and mire yourself in a debt trap, with cashback schemes. However, the discerning consumer is too smart to default on his payments and instead makes the best of these offers which can go up to fifteen percent and sometimes even more. Some of these offers are instant, and put money back into your account immediately, whereas others take a month or two or even more to refund the money.

The cashback offers are generally tied to credit cards offered by certain banks. If you don't have a credit card of the requisite bank for the offer, it pays to have friends willing to let you use their credit cards to avail the benefit. What good are friends if they can't put their money where their mouths are. Just make sure

math to figure out if it's worth meeting the minimum purchase criteria.

KEEP YOUR EYES OPEN

It's one thing to come up with innovative means to look for deals, but often times we tend to fixate on a tree and miss the entire forest. Any e-commerce portal worth its salt has presence on social media networks, which run all sorts of special audience specific schemes and offers all the time. It's therefore prudent to follow big e-tailers on Facebook, Twitter and other social media platforms to keep updated with many exclusive offers, contests, and discount coupons that are open to subscribers quite often than not. For example, eBay sends excellent customised discount coupons from time to time, which makes a lot of difference to purchases that would otherwise be out of your budget.



Follow the right Twitter accounts and keep an eye out for such tweets

you follow the good etiquette of transferring money into your friends account in a timely manner. Or not, if you don't mind losing friends and/or teeth for a few thousand rupees. And speaking of getting the poop kicked out of you, make sure you thoroughly read the fine print before opting for the cashback offer. Any establishment that employs loan sharks isn't exactly worth trusting, so pay attention to the cashback clauses.

For example, if you're ₹300 short of being eligible for a cashback offer to the tune of 15 percent, make it a point to do the math and figure out if spending extra to meet the eligibility threshold works out better for you. Do the math and you'll find that adding 300 bucks worth of products to your cart to meet the ₹5,000 mark involves spending ₹4250, as opposed to ₹4700 if you don't add items worth ₹300 more to your cart. In a nutshell, keep an eye out for good cashback deals and do the

Scouring for discount coupons on the typical coupon websites is generally futile since a vast majority of those don't work at all. However, deal websites such as DesiDime and Twitter accounts such as <https://twitter.com/DealsForGeeks> have actual people curating deals that are verified and guaranteed to work. This is essentially reaping the hard work and serendipitous discoveries of real people aggregated to give you a wide choice of excellent offers that really work. The hardcore hardware and audio geeks amongst you would serve well by scouring the forum marketplaces such as Digit forums (digit.in/forum), Erodov and TechEnclave for direct/group deals from the distributors themselves. Well, that's about everything you need to hunt deals and know exactly how to maximise the benefit by using the system to your advantage. Happy hunting. 🍀

(with inputs from @ameyadalvi)